

BANGLADESH: GEOGRAPHY, DEMOGRAPHY & CULTURAL TRAITS



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OBJECTIVES OF THIS CLASS

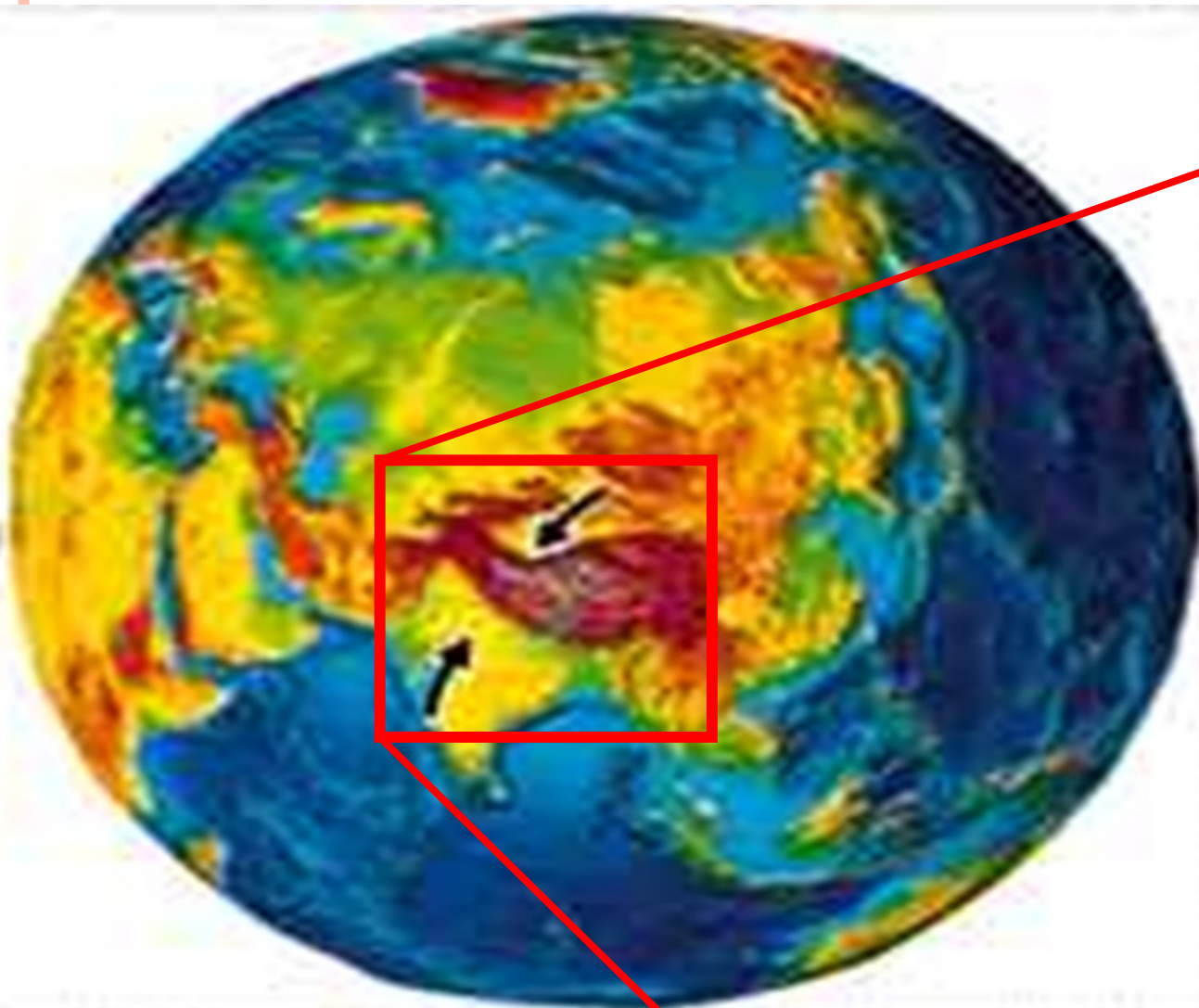
- Perceive Bangladesh through a brief analysis
- Know the Prime Geographical Features of Bangladesh
- Understand about key demographical features of Bangladesh.
- Analyze the crucial socio-cultural spectrums or indicators of Bangladesh
- Explore about the organs of the government
- Discuss the culture of Bangladesh

Bangladesh Facts and Figures

Official name	: People's Republic of Bangladesh
Location	: South Asia
Capital city	: Dhaka
Nationality	: Bangladeshi
Name of currency	: Taka
Area	: 1,47,570 sq.km
State language	: Bangla
Date of Independence	: March 26, 1971
Bangladesh Anthem	: Amar Shonar Bangla
National Animal	: Royal Bengal Tiger
National Bird	: Oriental Magpie Robin
National Fish	: Hilsa
National Flower	: White Water Lily
National Fruit	: Jackfruit
National Tree	: Mango Tree

THINK.....

- ❖ Suppose you have met an Australian Citizen one day. This Australian Citizen wants to Know about Bangladesh. How are you going to present Bangladesh to this Australian Citizen?



Position of Bangladesh

Geography of Bangladesh

LOCATION

Bangladesh is a South-Asian small country. It's total Area is about 147,570 square km.

It is situated from 20°34" north latitude to 26°38" north latitude and from 88°01" east longitude to 92°41" east longitude .

International Boundary	: 5138 km
Border with India	: 4156 km
Border with Myanmar	: 271 km
Coastline	: 711 km



Geography of Bangladesh

BOUNDARY & BORDER

Total boundary or international border line of Bangladesh is about 5138 km.

Border: West Bengal (India) on the west; Assam and Meghalaya on the north; Tripura and Mizoram together with Myanmar on the east; and Bay of Bengal on the south.

Maritime boundary: The political Sea line of Bangladesh is about 12 nautical miles and the exclusive economic zone of the country is 200 nautical miles.



THINK.....

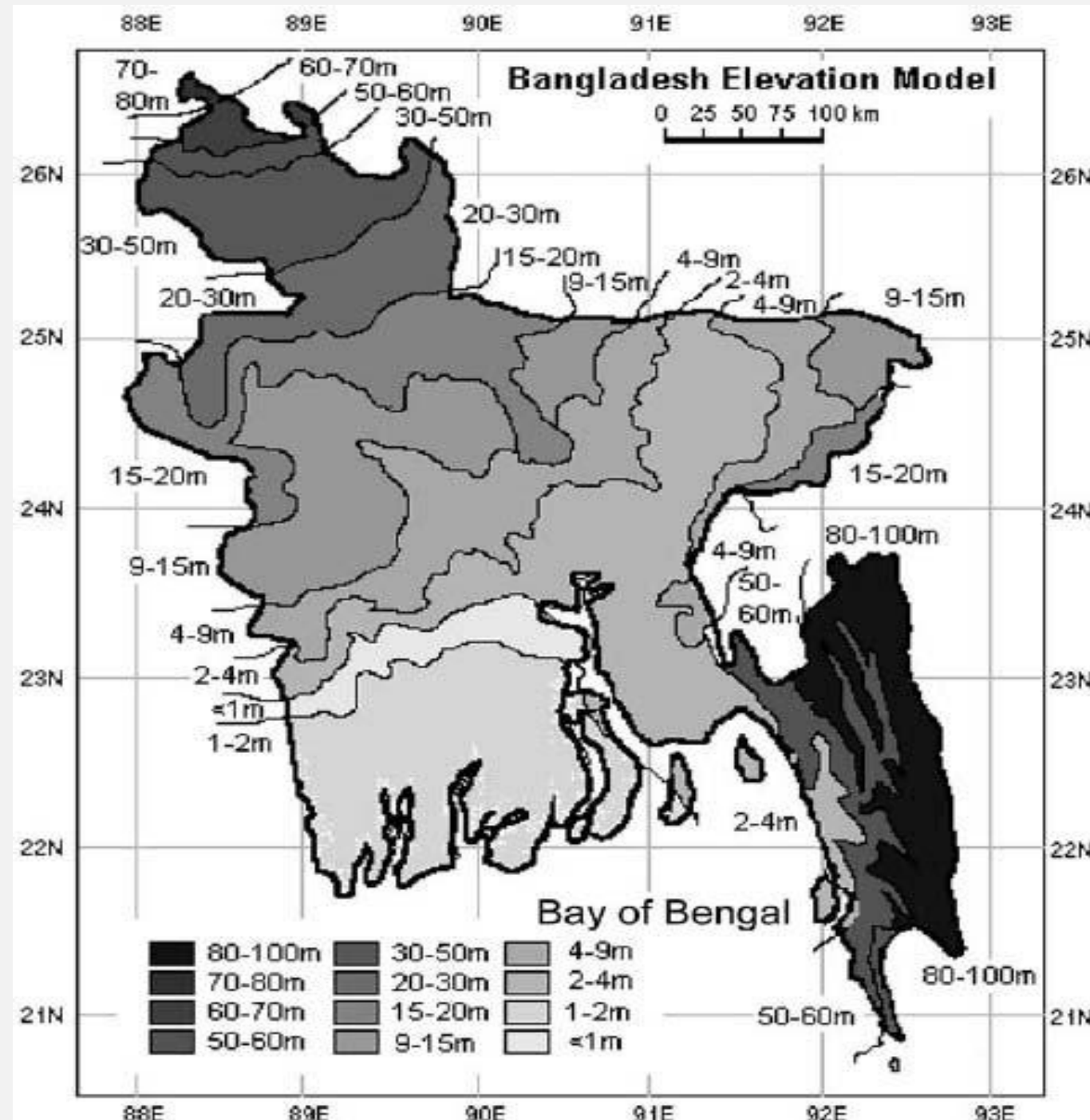
- Bangladesh shares an international boundary of 4156 KM with India. Does this Make India our most important Neighbor? How should Bangladesh continue its Foreign Affairs with India?
- With Myanmar, Bangladesh only shares 271 KM of international border. But in present days Myanmar is creating bigger problems for Bangladesh than any other state. Do you think higher amount of international boundary is crucial to create an influence in the foreign affairs for a neighboring country of ours. Please explain your answer with examples.

THINK....

- The Exclusive Economic Zone of Bangladesh in the maritime boundary is consisted with an area of 200 nautical miles. How would you use this area in favor of Bangladesh?
- What do you understand by political sea line? Bangladesh's political sea line is only of 12 nautical miles – is it good or bad?

Geography of Bangladesh

TOPOGRAPHY



Topography is a configuration of a land surface. There are three typical natural features in Bangladesh.

- A broad deltaic plain subject to frequent flooding.
- A slightly elevated relatively older plain
- A small hill region specially in Chittagong hills in southeast and low hills in northeast. Tajingdong or Bijoy' is the highest peak.

Bangladesh is also the largest delta of the world. The delta plain of the Ganges (Padma), Brahmaputra (Jamuna), and Meghna Rivers and their tributaries occupy 79 percent of the country.

THINK.....

- Some academicians argue that the topography of Bangladesh is the main reason behind the frequent flooding. Do you support this argument? If you do, then strengthen your support by formidable examples and if you don't, then explain logically the reasons behind your disbelief.
- What are the benefits and problems of being the largest delta of the world? Solidify your answer with rigorous examples.

Geography of Bangladesh

MINERAL RESOURCES

Bangladesh is not so rich in mineral resources. The principal energy resources are:

Natural gas: It is found in several small fields in the northeastern part. There are 24 discovered gas fields in Bangladesh.

Coal: There are five coalfields in Bangladesh.

Limestone, pottery clays, Hard Rock, Construction sand, Glass sand are also found in Bangladesh.



THINK.....

- In your own opinion, how do you think Bangladesh should use her mineral resources? Should we preserve our reserves of natural gas or should we be using it constantly?

Geography of Bangladesh

BANGLADESH



Bangladesh is a riverine country. About 700 rivers flow through the country. Most of the country's land is formed through mud brought by the rivers. These rivers play a significant role in the economic growth of the country.

The system of rivers can be divided into five major networks as follows :

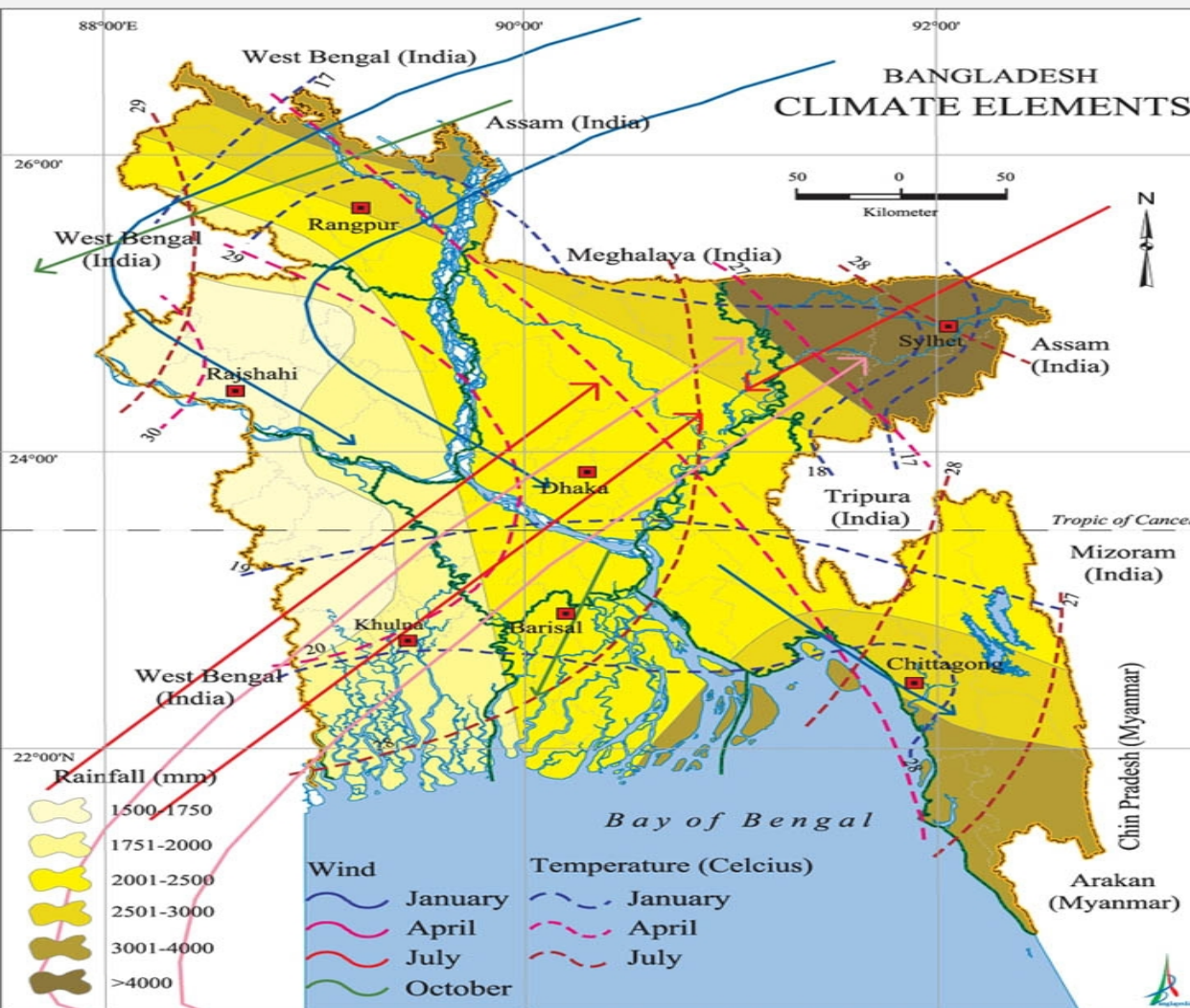
- ☐ Brahmaputra-Jamuna river system
- ☐ Ganges-Padma river system
- ☐ Surma-Meghna river system
- ☐ Tista river System
- ☐ Karnafuli river system

THINK.....

- An Economist argued that – “Being a riverine country, rivers play a significant role in the economic growth of Bangladesh”. Do you support this line of reasoning? If you do, then please provide arguments in favor of your belief. If you don't, then explain reasonably the stance you have taken.

Geography of Bangladesh

CLIMATE



Bangladesh is subject to devastating cyclones, originating over the Bay of Bengal, in the periods of April to May and September to November. Floods also occur in rainy season.

Straddling the Tropic of Cancer, Bangladesh has a tropical monsoon climate characterized by heavy seasonal rainfall, high temperatures, and high humidity.

It is the area of Sub-tropical monsoon. Mild winter (October to March); hot, humid & summer (March to June); humid, warm rainy monsoon (June to October).

In general, highest summer temperatures range between 30° to 40°C and April is the warmest month. January is the coldest month, when average temperature is about 10°C.

There are six seasons:

summer, rainy, autumn, late autumn, winter and spring. For practical purposes, three seasons are distinguishable: summer, rainy, and winter.

Demography of Bangladesh

Total Population: 14.97 Crore (2011 census)

16.51 Crore (2022 Census)

Population Growth Rate: 0.69% (2023)

Ethnic Group: Highly homogenous as the vast majority (about 98.5%) of Bangladeshis are of the Bengali ethno-linguistic group. Bengalis are an Indo-Aryan ethnic group native to the region of Bengal.

Languages: Over 98% people speak the Bengali language. Bangla is the official and state language of the country. English widely used by educated elite. Arabic used in many Muslim homes. Various tribal languages and regional languages used in local level.

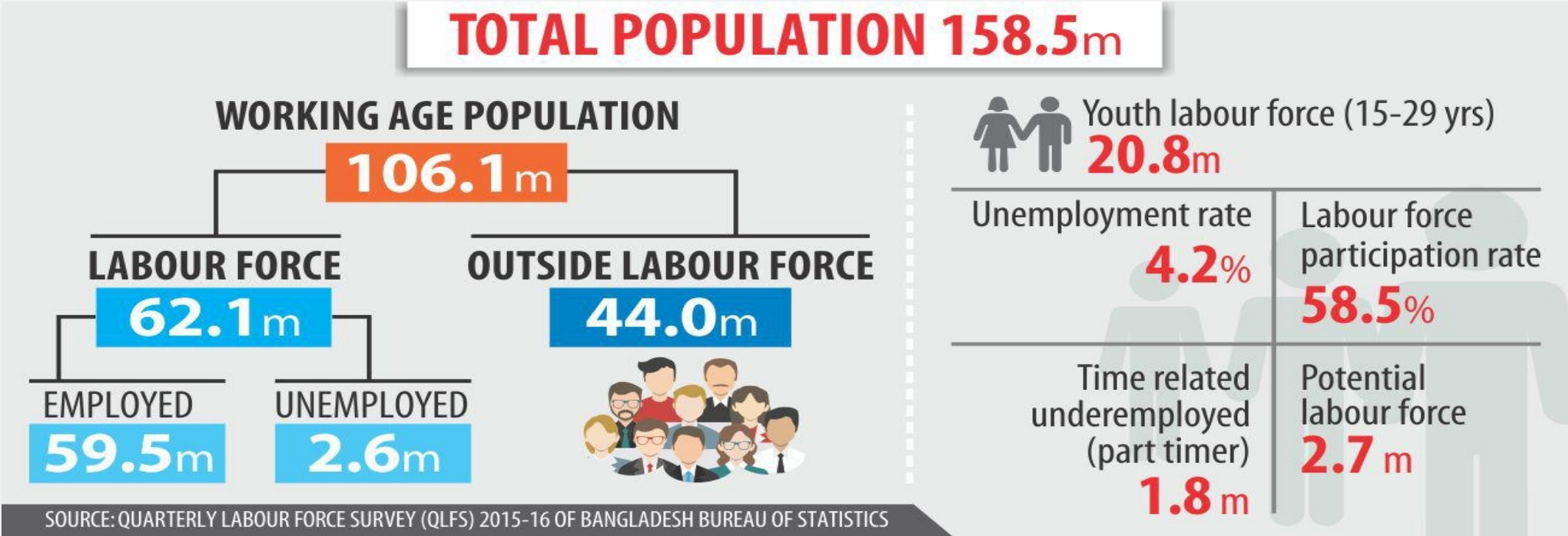
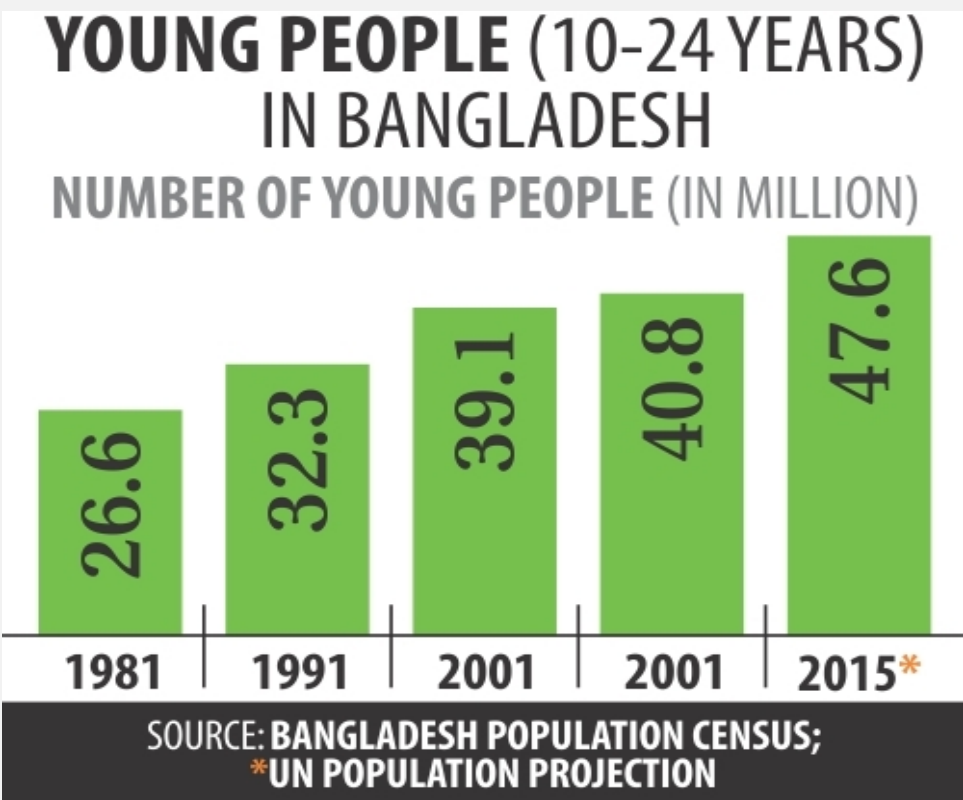
Health: Life expectancy almost equal for male and female, average 71.6 years (male-70.3 & female 72.9).

Religions: The main religion is **Islam** (89.7%), but a significant percentage of the population adheres to **Hinduism** (9.2%).

BANGLADESH POPULATION	
1950	3,78,95,000
2017	16,46,70,000
2030	18,55,85,000
2050	20,19,27,000
2100	17,35,49,000
GLOBAL RANK	
1950	12
2017	8
2050	8
2100	14
LIFE EXPECTANCY AT BIRTH	
1990-95	60
2005-10	69
2010-15	71.2
2015-20	72.9
2025-30	75.7
2045-50	79.9
2095-2100	87.5
SOURCE: "WORLD POPULATION PROSPECTS: THE 2017 REVISION", UN DEPARTMENT OF ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL AFFAIRS	

Demography of Bangladesh

Age Structure & Labor force: Since 2007 Bangladesh has had more people of working age than non-working, known as demographic dividend. Bangladesh got the window of demographic dividend but we have to transform it into economic dividend. Demographic dividend usually continues for 30 to 35 years. The dividend usually comes once for a country. The total labor force of Bangladesh is 62.1 million (2015).



THINK.....

- A Newspaper article reports that – “more than 65 percent of the population in Bangladesh are of working age (between 15 and 64)”. Do you think we are properly using this vast working force? What are your propositions for optimizing the productivity of this huge working force?
- Can you define “Demographic Dividend”? Does Bangladesh possess a “Demographic Dividend”? How do you think a country like Bangladesh can optimally use her “Demographic Dividend”?

Society and Social Stratification

Society can be defined as a group of people who share a common economic, social, and cultural infrastructure. It is an organization of people who share a common cultural and social background. The term "society" is the most fundamental one in sociology. It can be said that the society of Bangladesh is a homogenous society. Because the majority of people speak Bangla, the majority of people are Bangalees ethnically, and the majority of people are Muslim and Hindus religiously.

Social stratification is a system in which groups of people are divided into layers according to their relative property, identity, power, and prestige. It is also the division of society into categories, ranks, or classes. These divisions lead to social inequality—the unequal sharing of resources and social rewards.

Social Stratification in Bangladesh



THINK.....

- A Sociologist argues that middle-class youth in Bangladesh are very much eager to become government officers rather than becoming an independent entrepreneur or a job holder in the private sector. Do you support this sociologist's claim? Justify your belief by drawing both a statistical and analytical picture of the job market of Bangladesh.
- Do you think “culture” is the basic foundation behind social stratification in Bangladesh? Support your claim by creating balanced lines of arguments.

Social Stratification in Bangladesh

Social Stratification in Present Society

On the basis of income and wealth we can divide the society of Bangladesh into three broad categories though there are different sub groups.

UPPER CLASS

Industrialist, Businessman and Top Professionals etc.

MIDDLE CLASS

Professionals, Bureaucrats and Skilled Workers etc

LOWER CLASS

Social Stratification In Hindu Society

In the Hindu society in Bengal we got two caste division which are:

Brahmans

Upper class people

Non-Brahmans

Kayastha Baidya, Tanti, Swarnakar and Chamar etc.

Social stratification In Colonial Period

We noticed another different type of social stratification in the colonial period which was centered ownership of land. Like as:

Zamindars

The most powerful class in the agrarian structure.

Rich Peasant Class

During the colonial time we witnessed the emergence of a rich peasant class who occupied an important position.

Poor peasants

working class coming from the landless and marginal peasants.

Culture of Bangladesh

Culture: Culture is a word for the 'way of life' of groups of people, meaning the way they do things. According to MacIver, it is "the expression of our nature in our modes of living and thinking, intercourse, in our literature, in religion, in recreation and enjoyment." Different groups may have different cultures.

Tradition: Tradition is a belief or behavior passed down within a group or society with symbolic meaning or special significance with origins in the past.

Elements of Culture

The major elements of culture are symbols, language, norms, values, and artifacts.

Religion: Beliefs of society, some traditions.

Politics: Governance and laws of culture.

Language: The communication system of a culture. It is the most basic and most important element in a culture.

Norms: Norms decide the rules and regulations of society.

Symbols: The importance of symbols may differ for diverse people, belonging to different cultures.

Values: The values of a particular society get accumulated and move forward from generation to generation.

Artifacts: Artifacts can include objects recovered from archaeological sites.

Culture of Bangladesh

It can be said that the culture of Bangladesh is one of the most enriched cultures in Asia. How???

**Bangladesh has a rich, diverse culture. Its deeply rooted heritage is thoroughly reflected in its architecture, dance, literature, music, painting, and clothing.

**The three primary religions of Bangladesh (Islam, Hinduism, and Buddhism) have had a great influence on its culture and history.

**Bangladeshi culture was influenced by Aryan thoughts. Again, the ingredients of Muslim culture from Turkey, the Arab world, Iran, and the Middle East have influenced this culture.

**By the arrival of the Europeans, especially the British, a different cultural trend was set. In this way, over the course of time, our culture gradually developed with the essence of different cultures.

**The long political history of this region's peoples has developed their lifestyle by incorporating new items from various nations, races, and cultures of the world

Culture of Bangladesh (Cont..)

**Tribal dances are very popular among Bangladeshis. In the countryside, girls are in the habit of dancing to popular folk music.

**The land, the rivers, and the lives of the common people formed a unique culture that is different from that of neighboring regions. It has evolved over the centuries.

**The traditional music of Bangladesh is very popular in the Indian sub-continent. The classical, modern, and folk music of this region, specifically Bhatiali, Baul, Marfati, Murshidi, have a unique appeal and attraction. In a modern context, Rabindra Sangeet and Nazrul Geeti have a good position as well.

**Finally, the great movements, the Language Movement in 1952 and the Liberation War of Bangladesh in 1971, have impacted the art, culture, literature, poems, novels, dramas, movies, and songs of this region significantly.

Cultural Identity of Bangladesh

Food

Rice and fish are the main staple foods of the Bangladeshi people. The famous proverb "mache bhate bangali" translates as "Bangali by fish and rice." In Bangladesh, 70% of what they (people) eat is based on rice, which is their main source of carbohydrates.

Dress

The dress preferences in Bangladesh are unique. In rural areas, men casually wear Lungi with a shirt. On cultural and religious occasions, men have traditional wear called Panjabi-Payjama. For women, the traditional and main dress is the Shari. Young females wear salwar kameez. Men also wear Dhuti, Fatua, and formal dress. Muslim women also wear burkas

Sports

The national sport of Bangladesh is Kabaddi. The most popular game in the country is cricket, with football coming in second. The Bangladesh national cricket team goes by the nickname "Tigers. Traditional sports in the country include Kho-Kho and Lathi Khela.

Historical tradition

This is the tradition of a few thousand years. NakshiKantha (embroideredquilt), said to be indigenous to Bangladesh, is made from old cotton clothes, predominantly discarded saris, dhotis, and lungis.

FESTIVALS AND CELEBRATIONS

Religion	Statehood	Anthography legacy
Religious Observances: Many festivals and celebrations have their roots in religious beliefs and practices. These events often commemorate significant religious events, figures, or principles. Christmas, Diwali, Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha, and Hanukkah in Judaism.	National, Social and Community Events: Some celebrations are sourced and organized to foster a sense of nation, national unity, or social bonding. Countries often have national holidays that commemorate historical events like independence day. It includes parades, and community gatherings.	Anthography legacy: Some celebrations based on community's heritage, customs, and traditions that sourced and continued from ethnographic history, language, lifestyle, geographic location, season, and even cuisine. These celebrations often involve rituals and activities of local fairs, and community gatherings etc, it also tied to the changing of seasons.
Eid ul-Fitr: The celebration of Eid ul-Fitr has become a part of the culture of Bangladesh. The government of Bangladesh declares a holiday for three days on Eid-ul Fitr.	Language Movement Day: Language Movement Day is a unique part of the culture of Bangladesh. This day is observed to pay tribute to the martyrs who sacrificed their lives in 1952 and	Independence Day on March 26, which is a national day also.

FESTIVALS AND CELEBRATIONS

Victory Day: Another important state festival is observed on December 16th every year as the "Victory Day" of the country.

Eid ul-Fitr: The celebration of Eid ul-Fitr has become a part of the culture of Bangladesh. The government of Bangladesh declares a holiday for three days on Eid-ul Fitr.

Eid-e-Miladunnabi: Eid-e-Miladunnabi is the birth and death anniversary of the great Prophet Hazrat Muhammad (s), which is a very important day for the Muslim community.

Durga Puja: The Hindu community observes its biggest religious festival, popularly known as Durga Puja, throughout the country for ten days.

Christmas: The main festival of the Christmas community, popularly known as "Bara Din (Christmas Day)", is celebrated on December 25th, and it is also a govt. holiday.

Buddha Purnima: The main and most important religious festival of the Buddhist community is Buddha Purnima, observed throughout the country.

Along with the mentioned festivals, the people of Bangladesh also observe.....

#Jabbar er Boli Khela

#Nobanno Utsab

Muslims Observe-.....

Eid-ul-Azha

Muharram

Bishwa Istima

Buddhists Observe-.....

Baishakhi Purnima

Maghi Purnima

Hindus Observe-.....

Saraswati Puja

Kali Puja etc.

Culture & Traditions-Norms & Values





THINK.....

- Do you think Cultural Festivals are important for Bangladesh?
- What kind of cultural festivals do you celebrate?
- How can cultural festivals be helpful to conserve our culture?

Cultural Challenges

- ☐ Identity Crisis
- ☐ Over Smartness
- ☐ Cultural Conflicts
- ☐ Misuse of ICT tools
- ☐ Addiction to Drugs
- ☐ Impact of Globalization
- ☐ Value structure deterioration
- ☐ Blindness to Western Culture
- ☐ Lack of Cultural Organization
- ☐ Tendency to Imitate Foreign Culture
- ☐ Advancement of Satellite Channels
- ☐ Irregular Arrangement of Cultural Programs
- ☐ Lack of Knowledge & Respect to Own Culture

GLOBALIZATIONAL IMPACT ON BENGALI CULTURE

- **Music:** switching to western & Indian pop rock songs
- **Dance:** Hiphop, salsa are getting more popular than traditional dances
- **Movies:** new movies have Bollywood, Hollywood touch. Theatre dramas are getting rare.
- **Festivals:** Valentines' day, friendship day, father's day, etc western festivals are also now celebrating.
- **Dresses:** western dresses become more popular.

THINK.....

- An Anthropologist argues that – “Bangladeshi Culture is in the face of extinction in the era of globalization”. What are your opinions on this argument? Do you think we should reject western culture?
- Have you ever suffered from identity crisis in your life? If you have, then explain the situation which forced you to this crisis. Do you think identity crisis should be seen as a usual incident in the era of globalization?
- Do you think English should be the official language in Bangladesh? Explain your stance with practical examples.

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Thank you all.